

Death Rattle

The NCRB report on suicides uncovers some disturbing trends

Nationwide Suicides

More than one lakh people (1,25,017) committed suicide during 2008—an increase of **1.9%** over the 2007 figure. The year 2008 saw 19.4% more suicides than 10 years ago (1,04,713 in 1998).

Family Suicides

484 deaths in family suicides, consisting of 202 males and 282 females, were reported in 2008. The highest number of cases were reported from Bihar (102), followed by Rajasthan (86) and Andhra Pradesh (40). The national rate of suicide (the number of suicides per one lakh population) is **10.8**. Bihar at just **1.1** is at the bottom, higher than only Lakshadweep.

Causes of Suicide

Family problems and illness, accounting for **23.8%** and **21.9%**, were the major causes of suicide. Love affairs (3%), bankruptcy, dowry disputes and poverty (2.4% each) were the other causes.

Professional Status of Suicide Victims

Housewives (24,367) accounted for **54.8%** of the total female victims and nearly **19.5%** of those who committed suicide. Government servants were merely **1.7%** of the total suicide victims.

Marital Status of Suicide Victims

70.3% of the suicide victims were married, **22.1%** unmarried and **3.3%** were divorcees or separated. The proportion of widows and widowers was **4.3%**.

depression in Bihar's rural society too," says Sharma.

More importantly, the NCRB report attributes 7 per cent of the total suicides to mental illness—a fact that Union Health and Family Welfare Minister Ghulam Nabi Azad also submitted in the Rajya Sabha. In Bihar, mental sickness is perhaps the most under-reported issue because of the stigma attached to it. Left unreported, depression increases in duration and intensity, and the person swings between extremes, says Sharma. According to him, the signs are so fleeting and subtle that they are misinterpreted by everyone, including doctors. "Depressed individuals complain about pains because

condition although the mind remains as low as before. Such patients are prone to committing suicide." Pushp-lata Singh, a married woman, jumped to death from her apartment in Patna on March 26 just when anti-depressants appeared to have worked.

Socio-economic changes also have an impact. The gap between reality and ambition has never been higher in Bihar, as has been the social and psychological impact of failure. In October last year, when the recession was at its worst, MBA graduate Arvind Pathak, 38, and his wife Mamta consumed poison after making their daughter Abhishi, 11, eat poisoned food. They died in Delhi where Pathak had been

SANTOSH KUMAR



MANJU SHAH, 26

On March 22, Shah killed her daughter Chulbuli, 3, before hanging herself to death. In 2006, she had married Deepak. Since it was a love marriage, her family had given no dowry to him. A low-grade worker in a Hyderabad factory, Deepak used to beat Shah after marriage. When Deepak didn't get any money from Shah's mother Asha Devi, he left her there, forcing her to commit suicide.

ASHA DEVI WITH HER GRANDDAUGHTER'S PHOTOGRAPH

society and family finds physical symptoms acceptable rather than psychological ones," says Sharma.

Experts also say that the family's role as a support system has remained intact, but its healing ability has diminished with growing individualism. On March 24, a young man called Dilip Paswan shot himself dead in Patna when even sleeping pills failed to help. His could be an example of how clinical depressions are overlooked in Bihar. Cautioning against overlooking a patient who seems to have improved, Sharma says, "We relax by thinking the worst is over. But the presumed improvement could just be better physical

searching for a job.

It is about time to peep inside families, but that is easier said than done. "In general, many are not likely to talk about their psychological problems," says Sharma. Stresses have been building up on different fronts with marital conflict a huge factor, he notes. What happened in Abhay's case should have been a wake-up call for legislators to think about the stresses built into their lives.

One day, Khushi will be told everything, and it is anybody's guess how traumatic that will be. Her sorrow will only be stretched across her young years. And that only makes matters worse, much worse. ■